Easy Guide to Everyday Tech Terms

Technology can sometimes seem like it has its own language. Here are some common terms explained in simple, everyday language.

1. GETTING ONLINE

What is “Wi-Fi”?

Think of it like: A wireless bridge to the internet.

What it means: Wi-Fi allows devices such as phones, tablets, and computers to connect to the internet without a cable.

Example: When you connect your phone to the Wi-Fi at the library, you can use the internet without using your cellular data.

What is a “Web Browser”?

Think of it like: A car that takes you to different places.

What it means: A web browser is an app you use to visit websites on the internet.

Examples: Google Chrome, Apple Safari, and Microsoft Edge.

Remember: The browser is the tool you use to visit websites. The internet is the larger network you are connecting to.

Search Engine

Think of it like: A librarian helping you find information.

What it means: A search engine helps you find websites, answers, images, and other information online.

Examples: Google, Bing, DuckDuckGo.

What is a “URL”?

Think of it like: A street address.

What it means: A URL, also called a **web address**, tells your browser where to find a website or a specific webpage.

Example: www.yourlibrary.org

You can usually find the URL in the address bar at the top of your browser.

🔗 What is a “Link”?

Think of it like: A sign pointing you somewhere.

What it means: A link is something you can click or tap to open another webpage, document, or online location.

Safety tip: Be careful about clicking links in unexpected emails or text messages.

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2. ACCOUNTS AND SIGNING IN

📧 Email Address

Think of it like: Your mailing address on the internet.

What it means: An email address tells other people where to send electronic messages to you.

Example: name@example.com

👤 What does “Sign In” or “Log In” mean?

Think of it like: Showing your ID to enter a building.

What it means: Signing in or logging in means entering your account information so a website or app knows who you are.

You will usually enter a username, email address, phone number, and/or password.

🔑 What is a “Password”?

Think of it like: A key to a locked door.

What it means: A password is a secret combination of letters, numbers, and/or symbols used to protect an account.

Remember:

- Keep your passwords private.
- Avoid using the same password for every account.
- Don't give your password to someone who contacts you unexpectedly.

What is “Two-Factor Authentication” (2FA)?

Think of it like: Two locks on your front door.

What it means: Two-factor authentication adds a second security check when you sign in to an account.

For example, after entering your password, you might be asked for a code from your phone or an authentication app.

Tip: If a website offers 2FA, turning it on can make your account much harder for someone else to access.

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3. STAYING SAFE ONLINE

What is “Spam”?

Think of it like: Junk mail in your mailbox.

What it means: Spam is unwanted email or other unwanted messages.

Some spam is simply annoying, but some messages are designed to trick you.

Tip: You can usually delete spam without opening it or responding to it.

What is “Phishing”?

Think of it like: A stranger pretending to be someone you know.

What it means: Phishing is an attempt to trick you into giving away personal information, such as a password, credit-card number, or other sensitive information.

A phishing message might pretend to come from your bank, a government agency, a company, or even someone you know.

- Creates a sense of urgency or threatens you.
- Asks for a password or financial information.
- Tells you to click an unexpected link.
- Seems unusual or different from messages you normally receive.
- Claims you have won a prize you did not enter to win.
- Asks you to pay with gift cards, cryptocurrency, or wire transfers.

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4. FILES, PHOTOS, AND STORAGE

What is “Downloading”?

Think of it like: Bringing something home from a store.

What it means: Downloading means taking something from the internet and saving it to your device.

Internet → Your device

Example: You download a PDF from a library website to your computer.

What is “Uploading”?

Think of it like: Mailing something from your home.

What it means: Uploading means sending something from your device to the internet.

Your device → Internet

Example: You upload a photo from your phone to a website.

Attachment

Think of it like: Putting a document inside an envelope.

What it means: An attachment is a file sent along with an email or message.

What is the “Cloud”?

Think of it like: A storage locker you can access online.

What it means: Your files, photos, and other information can be stored on computers operated by an online service instead of only on your own device. You can usually access them from another device by signing in.

Example: Photos saved to iCloud or Google Photos can be available on your phone, tablet, or computer.

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5. Apps and Devices

📱 What is an “App”?

Think of it like: A tool in a toolbox.

What it means: An app (short for “application”) is a program designed to perform a particular task.

Examples: There are apps for email, weather, banking, video calls, maps, and many other activities.

🔄 What is an “Update”?

Think of it like: A routine tune-up for your device.

What it means: An update is a change provided by the company that makes your software or device. Updates can fix problems, improve security, and add new features.

Tip: Keeping your device and apps updated is an important part of staying safer online.

6. COMMUNICATION

💬 Text Message vs. Email

Think of it like:

- Text message = a quick note to a phone.
- Email = a letter sent online.

What it means: Both are ways to communicate, but text messages usually go directly to a phone number, while emails are sent to an email address.

⭐ Remember These Five Things

🔒 **Keep your passwords private.**

🔗 **Be careful with unexpected links.**

📱 **Use two-factor authentication when it is available.**

🔄 **Keep your devices and apps updated.**

❓ **When you're unsure, ask a trusted person or your library for help.**

It's okay not to know. Technology can be confusing for everyone. Asking for help is a smart thing to do.